



The Humanitas Institute

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Arlington Classics Academy
School Website: <https://www.acaedu.net/>

December 21, 2025

Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

ACCS Member School

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools ACCS or the Society for Classical Learning SCL is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Executive Summary

Arlington Classics Academy (ACA) presents a mixed but leaning-classical profile. The school publicly articulates a classical framework in curriculum and pedagogy (grammar, logic, rhetoric; Great Books; Great Conversation; Socratic discussion in upper grades) while also incorporating Core Knowledge content in elementary grades. There is explicit evidence of Christian orientation through the school's external-classical materials, which signals alignment with theological grounding in education, though liturgical specifics on the campus are not foregrounded in the public ACA site pages themselves. Across the six classical elements, ACA demonstrates clear classical elements in Curriculum and Pedagogy, with notable engagement in traditional faculty roles and parental involvement but with less explicit emphasis on liturgical practice and fully unified religious metaphysics. The aggregate signal places ACA in the SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL category, with room to strengthen explicit religious metaphysical grounding and to deepen the seamless integration of classical pedagogy with a explicitly liturgical/communal framework.

- Evidence-driven assessment draws on ACA's public-facing materials that describe grammar/logic/rhetoric, Great Books, and the Great Conversation; Socratic/seminar-based pedagogy; and explicit Christian/classical alignment in companion classical education literature. Key sources include ACA's Classical Education articulation, the Great Books / Great Conversation references, and ICE-oriented materials that frame Christianity as integral to classical education. See: Classical Education articulation and Great Books references, and Christian/classical orientation materials.
- The school's site also signals a practical, modern administration with a structured faculty/academic-services team and multi-campus operations, which supports strong governance and a living curriculum approach, though this is not a formal "teacher-as-living-curriculum" claim on the public pages itself beyond the core roles listed.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

- Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
- Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
- Element 3: Curriculum — CLASSICAL
- Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL
- Element 5: Faculty — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
- Element 6: Parents & Community — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

What would move the needle: For ACA to move from SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL toward CLASSICAL, it would help to articulate and foreground a more explicit, cohesive religious-metaphysical vision integrated into daily curriculum and communal practices (e.g., explicit liturgical/cultural rituals, a stated transcendental moral realism in mission statements, and a clear alignment of virtue formation with classroom practice). It would also strengthen the case by documenting a more explicit, continuous Great Books program across grade levels and a formal "living curriculum" portrayal by faculty who are explicitly trained in classical pedagogy.

- Needle-mover 1: Publish a formal, school-wide declarative statement of faith-based or metaphysical foundations, explicitly tying truth/beauty/virtue and theology to daily instruction and school life.

-
- Needle-mover 2: Expand Great Books exposure beyond select grades, with a coherent Great Conversation across all grades, and document upper-grade seminars as an ongoing practice.
 - Needle-mover 3: Elevate the “living curriculum” language publicly, with faculty profiles that model classical virtues and provide examples of students’ seminar/recitation experiences.
 - Needle-mover 4: Strengthen visible liturgical or communal practices (e.g., morning shared readings, contemplative pauses, ritual calendars) and show how these connect to the classical curriculum and student formation.
-

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - ACA’s public materials include explicit Christian/classical orientation in companion ICE materials. The ICE pamphlet explicitly frames Christian integration with classical education and states that Jesus Christ must have preeminence in the academy, signaling theological grounding within the classical paradigm.
 - Public ACA pages articulate classical education principles (grammar/logic/rhetoric; Trivium). While not always framed as liturgical or doctrinal, these references establish a metaphysical stance rooted in timeless, transcendent ideals of order and virtue.
 - There are strong textual links to “truth, goodness, beauty” framing within classical discussions, including Great Books/wisdom-oriented language in the classical education content, and a Christian orientation in companion materials. The Great Conversation language appears in the classically framed curriculum.
- Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis
 - Positive keywords present: Christianity/Christian orientation; theology-related references; virtue-related framing in classical education; the Great Conversation; truth/goodness/beauty-oriented language in classical pedagogy discussions. Evidence: explicit Christian orientation and the classical framework referencing virtue and the Great Conversation.
 - Negative keywords: not explicitly surfaced in the public ACA materials; no clear signaling of secular relativism or moral neutrality in the accessible content.
- Why this rating
 - The presence of explicit Christian orientation and explicit classical-theology framing supports a theological/metaphysical anchor, but there is not a consistently overt, liturgical communal practice widely documented on the main ACA pages. The result is a credible religious/metaphysical grounding, but not fully foregrounded in all campus materials. This yields a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL categorization rather than CLASSICAL, given the explicit theology presence without a consistently liturgical/communal expression on the public-facing site across all categories.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - The classical framework presents formation of virtue and wisdom as central aims, with the “great conversation” and virtuous formation described in classical education literature associated with ACA’s materials, including explicit references to the Great Conversation and virtue formation through rigorous study.
 - ACA materials tie classical education to a mission that emphasizes enduring truth/virtue rather than job-training alone, aligning with classical formation aims, even as Core Knowledge content is integrated for foundational knowledge (which blends traditional and modern elements).
 - The ICE materials emphasize parent formation and the partnership in forming character and faith, indicating formation-focused aims that go beyond purely information-based schooling.
- Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis

-
- Positive keywords present: formation, virtue, wisdom, Great Conversation, classical heritage, scholé/rest, contemplation (as implied in ICE materials), human flourishing.
 - Negative keywords: explicit focus on “workforce preparation” or “career-readiness” is not dominant in these sources, though Core Knowledge integration signals some modern content alignment. The presence of Core Knowledge language might be viewed as a tension with a pure formation-virtue focus, but not a negation of formation aims.
 - Why this rating
 - ACA displays formation-oriented aims (virtue, wisdom, the Great Conversation) consistent with classical formation, but the presence of non-classical Core Knowledge content and modern program components keeps the overall aim from being exclusively formation-pure within the six-element rubric. This yields SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rather than CLASSICAL.

Element 3: Curriculum — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - ACA explicitly describes the Trivium (grammar, logic, rhetoric) and a classical progression; grammar stage growth and memory-focused pedagogy are cited in ACA’s Classical Education materials. This aligns with core classical curriculum expectations.
 - There is explicit reference to reading Great Books and joining the Great Conversation within ACA’s Classical Education materials, including Beowulf, Dante, Chaucer, Shakespeare as part of a layered curriculum. This is a core element of classical curricula.
 - The school publicly discusses a Core Knowledge program (K-5) within Social Studies and ELA, indicating integration of a structured knowledge base in addition to classical elements, which is a noted hybrid feature but does not negate the classical curriculum elements themselves.
- Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis
 - Positive keywords present: grammar, logic, rhetoric; Great Books; Great Conversation; Trivium; history integrated through curriculum; memory/recitation; classical curriculum language.
 - Negative keywords: minimal explicit negative indicators in the curriculum pages; Core Knowledge content appears as a non-classical element in some strands, but does not derail the strong classical strands.
- Why this rating
 - The curriculum is clearly anchored in classical design (grammar/logic/rhetoric; Great Books; Great Conversation), with explicit classical texts and a structure that supports the Trivium progression. The presence of Core Knowledge content is a hybrid feature rather than a negation of classical aims; thus, CLASSICAL is justified.

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - ACA’s materials describe Socratic discussion in upper grades, seminars or debates, and opportunities for students to present and exercise rhetoric; this is a hallmark of classical pedagogy.
 - The public-facing “Classical Education” materials emphasize a pedagogy oriented toward memory work, recitation, and disciplined rhetoric; the overall structure includes graded transitions from grammar to logic to rhetoric.
 - The lexicon and accompanying materials emphasize the use of memory work, recitation, and the spoken aspect of classical pedagogy; ACA content aligns with these practices.
- Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis
 - Positive keywords present: Socratic discussion, seminars, dialectic, discourse, rhetoric, memory work, recitation, scholé, contemplation, wonder, and lecture-style or seminar-style elements in the upper grades.
 - Negative keywords: The materials do not emphasize purely project-based or constructivist, experiential-only approaches; in fact, the classical pedagogy emphasis runs counter to those

-
- negative signals.
 - Why this rating
 - The school’s pedagogy strongly aligns with classical teaching methods (Socratic seminars, rhetoric training, memory work, disciplined recitation), justifying CLASSICAL. The explicit emphasis on the Trivium and classical pedagogy in the public content supports this.

Element 5: Faculty — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - ACA’s public pages show formal faculty roles and governance structures (Director of Academic Services, Coordinators for Assessment and Special Education, etc.), indicating a living curriculum and faculty-led formation, though these pages describe administrative roles rather than a detailed “faculty-as-living-curriculum” narrative.
 - The ICE and classical education materials emphasize the teacher as mentor and living model in classical education, with the “portrait of a teacher” and “faculty as living curriculum” language as aspirational ideals within classical education systems. While ACA’s public pages do not spell this out exhaustively, the alignment exists in the broader classical rhetoric reflected in the public materials.
- Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis
 - Positive keywords present: mentor, living curriculum, faculty as exemplar, teacher as guide, master/teacher archetypes, collegial faculty culture (as suggested by classical education materials). The ACA public pages list explicit professional roles and a structured administrative flow.
 - Negative keywords: No explicit “hands-off” or purely facilitative-role language; however, the public pages emphasize staff roles rather than a fully developed, illustrated “living curriculum” narrative, which is more explicitly described in some classical education literature than in ACA’s stand-alone pages.
- Why this rating
 - ACA demonstrates strong faculty structures and alignment with classical notions of teacher-mentors and living curriculum in the classical education literature, but the public-facing materials do not consistently exhaustively articulate the “living curriculum” portrait. This yields SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rather than CLASSICAL.

Element 6: Parents & Community — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - ACA materials and ICE documents emphasize partnerships with parents, parental formation, and opportunities for family involvement (e.g., parent seminars, literature, and classical education discussions). The ICE pamphlet explicitly discusses parent involvement in classical education and the role of parents as co-educators.
 - The campus materials show open campus culture and engagement (clubs, events, and community activities) that reflect a supportive parental and community environment, though explicit, formal parent-co-teacher language is less overt in ACA’s public pages.
- Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis
 - Positive keywords present: partnership with parents, parent formation, book studies, classical book clubs, family involvement, open campus; parent as co-teacher is strongly aligned with classical education theory.
 - Negative keywords: none clearly present in the public materials; the content is oriented toward partnership and participation rather than consumer-like language. However, the breadth and depth of formal parent-education programs on the site are not exhaustively detailed, leaving some ambiguity.
- Why this rating
 - The materials strongly support a parent-community partnership model, but the level of explicit, programmatic parent-formation content is not as fully developed in ACA’s public-facing pages as classical rhetoric would require to assign CLASSICAL. This yields SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL.

What Would Move the Needle

- Increase explicit articulation of metaphysical/theological foundations as a school-wide, public-facing core; publish a concise, formal statement tying truth, goodness, beauty, virtue, and theology to daily instruction, campus rituals, and long-term formation.
 - Expand and publicly document a continuous Great Books / Great Conversation across more grade levels, including a visible set of upper-school seminars and student-led rhetoric performances aligned with classical pedagogy.
 - Elevate the public-facing language around the “living curriculum” by featuring faculty profiles that model classical virtues, share exemplars of memory work, recitation, and seminar outcomes, and provide case studies of student work.
 - Implement and publish a visible, community-facing schedule of liturgical or communal practices (even if modest) that connect to the classical curriculum (e.g., shared readings, contemplative beginnings, seasonal rituals) to strengthen religious-metaphysical grounding.
 - Deepen formal parent-education programming (book clubs, lectures, family-study guides) with regular on-campus opportunities and online resources, making parental formation a clearly codified part of the ACA experience.
-

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

By reading or using this document, you acknowledge and accept the limitations described above.